rations, as did the Mughal army. ‘While people were crying for bread and taking each other’s lives,’ wrote Badauni, ‘the elephants of Himun’s army… were fed solely upon rice, and oil, and sugar.’ As soon as he was encamped in the plains of Tughlaqabad, Hemu unleashed his ferocious war elephants. Under the command of Tardi Beg, the Mughal amirs were undecided about whether to fight or flee and, irresolute and unconvinced, were roundly defeated by Hemu, who captured 100 of their elephants, 1,000 Arab horses, and an immense quantity of booty. Part of the reason for Mughal indecision seems to have been the removal of powerful Mughal amirs from the region by Bairam Khan himself, who had moved quickly to neutralize competitors after he became wakil-e-saltanat. Hemu now took the grandiose title of Raja Hemchandra Vikramaditya and Tardi Beg fled towards the Punjab where Bairam Khan was waiting for him, fury and murder in his heart.

That Tardi Beg and Bairam Khan were headed for a clash without the accommodating presence of Humayun had been clear for a long time. Of the small group of fifty-one nobles who had come to Hindustan with Humayun in 1555, almost all were foreign-born Muslims. More than half of those were high status chiefs from Central Asian Turki–Chaghatai or Uzbek lineages while a smaller group of sixteen noblemen were Persian Shias. Tardi Beg, the Turki-speaking brusque old Central Asian Sunni nobleman from the retinue of Padshah Babur himself, would have considered himself superior in every way to Bairam Khan. To Tardi Beg, the Shia Bairam Khan would probably always have remained Humayun’s muhrdar, his seal bearer, and a negligible Persian parvenu. Early in Humayun’s reign Bairam Khan had wanted to sit on the same carpet as Tardi Beg, who was Governor of Etawah at the time, and Tardi Beg had peremptorily refused. But Bairam Khan’s stature had risen meteorically since then, with Humayun taking Bairam Khan to Persia, and appointing him ataliq to Akbar. Though Bairam Khan still addressed the older man as tugan, or elder brother, their standing had changed enormously. Bairam Khan meanwhile needed to act quickly to bring order within the ranks of the fiercely independent Central Asian noblemen who each, according to the scoffing Ferishta, ‘esteemed himself at least equal to Keikobad and Keikaoos (the legendary Persian heroes)’. Tardi Beg wanted to continue the retreat, possibly all the way back to his stronghold of Kabul, and Bairam Khan needed to act decisively and unambiguously to show the nobility that there was a new kingmaker who would not tolerate defeat or disaffection. As to the exact sequence of events